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Mickey Roker

Drummer Mickey Roker was born in Miami in 1932. He grew up in the active jazz atmosphere of Philadelphia and jammed with Jimmy Heath, Lee Morgan and McCoy Tyner. Mickey re-settled in New York in the late '50's and performed with Duke Pearson, Nancy Wilson and Art Farmer, later teaming up with Joe Williams from 1961-63. Much of the '70's was spent with Dizzy Gillespie, with whom he shared a love and talent for Latin music. Such musical giants as Oscar Peterson, Ray Brown and Sonny Rollins have called on Mickey to record and tour and he can be found playing across the country at major jazz venues and festivals.

Mickey was interviewed by Michael Woods aboard a cruise ship in the Caribbean on May 31, 1995.

MW: Good evening. We are on board the Royal Caribbean Cruise Line and we are filming a jazz archive for Hamilton College. Our guest today is Mickey Roker.

MR: Thank you. Glad to be here.

MW: Yes. Let me just ask you when did you get started playing and who were some of the people that you were influenced by?

MR: Well I started playing drums when I was about maybe six years old. And mostly military drums, marching band, stuff like that. And then I got drafted into the Army and that's when I decided I wanted to play swing — a set of drums. So everybody that played drums was a big influence on me you know because when you don't know anything, everything is exciting you know. But later on, after I learned about the drums, I fell in love with Kenny Clarke and Papa Jo Jones and Vernel Fournier, oh, so many people, you know Philly Joe Jones. But the guy that I listened to in my developing stages in Philadelphia was a drummer named Specs Wright. Because Philly Joe Jones had already gone by the time I started playing. I didn't start playing until 1956. I got drafted in 1952 and I got out of the Army in 1955, so that's when I started to play, practice and practice, and I'm still trying to learn how to play.

MW: Who did you get some of your first gigs with?

MR: Well I played rhythm & blues in Philly with a band, a guy named King James. I did that for a year in a group with Jimmy Devine called the High Five. We had a band together for about a year, and then I decided that playing that way is so limited you know. So I devoted my life to playing jazz because it's more free, it's open you know, and you can express more rhythm. So then I started playing with people like Sam Reed, all these Philadelphia musicians, and Jimmy Heath and Jimmy Oliver. Jimmy Heath is the guy that introduced me to Milt Jackson years ago. So then in 1959 I went to New York to

play with Gigi Gryce. So I played with Gigi Gryce for a couple of years, played with Ray Bryant for a couple of years, and then that's when I joined Joe Williams' band with the Junior Mance Trio.

MW: Tell us about Joe. How do you feel his voice typifies jazz vocals?

MR: Because he can really sing the blues. And if you play jazz, if it doesn't feel like the blues is involved, then it's classical. You know what I'm saying? Jazz, the basics of jazz is the blues.

MW: That's the emotional well.

MR: Right. You know the Gospel feelings, you know, even the greatest saxophone players, the greatest instrumentalists, they know how to put blues into their statements you know. Not to say that they've got to be playing blues like B.B. King, I mean just the feeling, the happy feeling of the blues.

MW: Now that's something I want you to talk about. You said "the happy feeling of the blues." All right now elaborate on that.

MR: Well you know the blues have many faces. Some people cry man the ol' lady left 'em and all that, but sometimes the blues can be happy man, because it's a feeling man that generates the spirit of Christ, which makes you happy, you know what I mean? You're saved. I mean you're pure, it's clean. So that type of blues is what I'm talking about you know. Like Milt Jackson, the way he plays the blues. It makes you want to jump up and dance you know, and so that's happy. That kind of blues.

MW: The thing I wanted to say about that and then you kind of elaborate on this is in the African-American community it came that when you play the blues, you express yourself. You don't just execute notes, black dots on a page. You express yourself.

MR: With emotion.

MW: With emotion. And the freedom involved in that became a kind of unspoken but musical camaraderie. In other words, when I hear you play that blues I can tell that that cost you something experientially.

MR: Oh, yeah. you express your life, you express the way you live. You know like some people that go to school formally, I'm not saying all, but some people they tend to play too classically. So it's something that has to be in you I believe. I think you have to be blessed. You have to be blessed. You have to have a certain talent for being able to play the blues and to really play the blues, you know, with feeling. Even though you're playing maybe rhythm changes, but it should still swing like the blues. Like the Gospel. It should always have that feeling in there. And that's one thing about Joe Williams that I like. You know he's so versatile. He can sing a ballad, and it's soulful, and he can sing an uptempo tune and it's soulful. But he can really sing the blues. And it's not jazz unless you have the blues instilled in there somewhere.

MW: So you can't learn it all out of a book.

MR: Well it's nice, in fact you should have something in your head too but you should also have something in your heart. And that's what the blues come out of, you know, out of your heart.

MW: Now I want to ask you a question. I know that you're capable of this because you just talked about it. But when you think of the blues, you think of either a blues singer, a blues guitar player 'cause he can bend them strings, or maybe a sax player, but how do you transfer those sounds to the drum kit?

MR: Well rhythm is our business. See we don't play changes on drums. We play rhythms. So we think in terms of, you see somebody walking down the street, it takes a certain rhythm. You think about life, you know what I'm saying? And you take your music and you express what you live and what you see, you see what I mean? The blues is something, it's a feeling that should be in you. From your grandmother, sitting on your grandmother's lap and she say, you know, "go to sleep little baby." You know what I'm saying? [sings] "Baby." So that's in you from a kid you know. So you know you go to school to learn academics, so that you can play with a bunch of guys that you don't even know, because you have the music. But you should never forget what's in your heart, what you learned from your grandma, you know?

MW: Tell us about playing with Dizzy.

MR: Now that was an experience for me I mean that will last me all my life. I'm from Philadelphia. Now I lived at 12th and Catharine. And Dizzy's mother lived in the 1300 block of Catharine Street. So I'd been seeing Dizzy Gillespie, because he has a nephew that he took care of. You know his brother died, his oldest brother died, so he assumed the responsibility for his nephew. So the same in my family. You know my uncle and my grandmother raised me. So Dizzy's mother and my grandmother, they used to go to the same church. So me and Dizzy's nephew, we went to school together. So I've been seeing Dizzy Gillespie all my life. So finally one day after I'd been in New York for a while, I was working with Lee Morgan at the time, and he loved Lee Morgan. So he used to come to hear us all the time. So he heard me and he liked me. So he asked me to join his band you know? And it was nine years of one of the greatest experiences I ever had in my life. He's a strong man, he knows a lot of music, and he knows rhythm. He can teach you rhythm. I think every drummer should have a chance to play with Dizzy Gillespie, you know when he was alive. Or they should really study his music. Everybody should. Him and Charlie Parker is the reason we play the way we play now. There's nothing newer. There's nothing newer than the way he and Charlie Parker play.

MW: Now I want to ask you about, pertaining to Dizzy, and then you kind of plug me in to it as a drummer. You know Dizzy was influential in bringing the Afro-Cuban beats into the

bebop and into other styles. And that's something that, you know, you're a specialist in. You're pretty good at that.

MR: Well I do the best I can.

MW: Tell us about how that affects the sound and how that changes the style.

MR: Well he loves rhythm. He loves rhythm, you know what I mean? He's like the king of bebop you know what I'm saying? He's like "titty boom, titty boom" so he fell in love with Chano Pozo and Patato Valdez, you know and Big Black, I mean these are great conga players. And he just loves that kind of music. And for me it was beautiful man because he taught me some rhythms — he taught me six-eight rhythms, and different Latin beats, but he loved six-eight rhythm, that are so simple, but still complicated you know? If he don't show you, it's even hard to conceive of these rhythms. And it's hard for me to express because I had to learn it from him you know. But he's a great man, Dizzy Gillespie, he's knows everything about music. And he just loved, you know, the Afro-Cuban beat you know. And it infiltrated into jazz you know.

MW: You know jazz, what kind of separates jazz from other forms of music, like European classical music, is the vitality and the pervasive nature of rhythm. Could you elaborate on that and tell us how that rhythm is different in, particularly in the African-American community and in the way it enunciates jazz, than rhythm in other styles of music or other cultures.

MR: Well an eighth note is an eighth note, but it's the way the eighth notes are played. Some people play 'em like [claps]. But in the Afro community, it's [claps] it's dotted. That's the whole difference. And if you can play with that type of feeling instilled in the rhythm then you have the blues and then you have Afro-Cuban all at the same time. Because they play [claps]. You hear the six-eight? And then the shuffle. [claps] And that's the only difference, is— because the notes are the same but it's the way you play the notes. And it's just a feeling that you have to have. It's hard for me to explain a feeling. I'm not, you know, it's something that you have to do you know. And somebody has to teach you how to do it.

MW: You know another thing I wanted to ask you about, learning this music. As you said, someone has to teach you, but then you also have to experience it.

MR: Right. You learn under pressure really. That's how you really learn. It's not easy for young guys now to get jazz gigs because there is not that many places for them to play. You know everything is, if you look at TV, everything is more rock or fusion you know? So I think everybody has to pay their dues and get a chance to play this type of music because it's the newest music happening and it's very, how do you say, it's very free, it's free. But you really have to know your instrument, you know, in order to be free. That's the main thing is that if you know your instrument, then you are truly free.

MW: In other words it's almost a dichotomy by saying the more disciplined you are on the instrument, the more freedom you afford yourself.

MR: Right. Sure.

MW: You also said that you learn under pressure. Give us if you can a situation in which you learned to do something under pressure.

MR: Well when I first started to play man, before I played my first gig I would practice and practice because I didn't go to, I couldn't afford to go to school, so I learned from friends you know, and we'd play. And I went to this jam session one time, and I mean you're talking about embarrassing, man, but it really made me go to work. I mean I learned a very valuable lesson that night. It was time for me to play. Everybody had a time to play you know? So they started to play [scats] Waltzhatten. It's a three-four rhythm. And I say [scats].

MW: Uh oh, uh oh, talk about polyrhythms.

MR: But I didn't know nothing about no polyrhythms back then you know. 'Cause I was self taught you know, and I had never heard a waltz before you know. I mean not to know that it was a waltz. So anyway, the guys are turning around and looking at me man, and I'm wondering what's wrong. Because the beat ain't right, man, it ain't matching up. So man that's when I learned that there was a different rhythm other than four-four. But if I hadn't gone to that jam session and put myself in a position like that, I never would have learned that. I mean it would have taken me even more time. But because I went and had enough nerve to get on stage. So anyway, who pulled my coat -- there's a great drummer named Donald Bailey. They called him Donald Duck. He used to play drums with Jimmy Smith. Great drummer man. He played with a lot of people. So he got me on the side and he said "Man you know in rhythm, some bars, some measures have four beats, some measures have two beats, some measures have five beats, and some measures have three beats. Some measures even have seven beats." And then that's when I learned about the differences you know? And so that was a great lesson for me you know. But you're talking about pressure man, I started sweating man. But it was beautiful man, because I went and I practiced. And I practiced. And the next time I went to a jam session they didn't play anything in three-four.

MW: But that sense of readiness. You know you said something else about the jam sessions. You know when jazz first started moving into the colleges, a lot of administrators didn't understand or even think that jam sessions were necessary.

MR: It's very important.

MW: But how else you going to work your ideas out?

MR: It's very important man. Because we used to have jam sessions every day of the week at different people's houses. Okay, Sunday was my day. They had jam session at my house

on Sunday. You know guys like McCoy Turner and Kenny Barron and Reggie Workman and Arthur Harper, and a lot of the Philadelphia guys like "C" Sharp, and oh, man, most of the guys around Philadelphia. And we would work tunes out. That's how we learned how to try to play jazz. You know we would learn the songs. You got to learn the music first. Then you learned what rhythm goes. And there are certain tunes where you can put different rhythms on you know? It doesn't always have to be the same rhythm you know? And that's what's so beautiful about jazz because you can do it differently. You don't have to do it the same way the other guy did it you know. And you learn, a lot of times you get a gig and there might not be any music. And they might call a song that you don't know. You know what I'm saying? So that's how you learn under pressure. Because you've got to play this song. You know what I'm saying? So you might mess up the first chorus. You might make a mistake. But by the second chorus, you'd better have it down, see? Or the third chorus, see? But the only way you can do that is you have to know your instrument. You've got to really know your rudiments from a rhythmic standpoint. You know for horn players, they've got to know their changes and their scales. But the drummers and percussion players, you've got to know your rudiments.

MW: You know I wanted to ask you about taking a drum solo. You know a lot of people don't really know how to listen to a drum solo. Many times when a drummer takes a solo on the form, the audience isn't even counting anymore. They're not even staying with him. Talk to us about the whole art of taking a solo on a percussion instrument.

MR: Well the way I solo I keep the melody in mind. I always sing the melody. See drummers make great singers because they don't get changes to play, so they've got to keep the melody in mind. And if you do that, you can put, the rhythm is so infinite man that there's so much you can do. But when people listen to a drummer play they want energy man, they want dynamics, they want the same thing that the drummer wants. It's up to the guy taking the solo to sell himself to the people that's listening you know. It's up to the player to make the people want to listen to him. So whatever, soloing is a different art. Some people can just solo man. Some people are natural soloists. Some people have to really work hard to really play an interesting solo. You know, and be clever, and still be basic.

MW: You know I had a chance, I was playing in a orchestra. I was playing the string bass in the string section behind Ramsey Lewis one night. And his drummer was basically saying he realized he was not a power drummer. So he got his excitement, he played a chorus and about every eight measures he got softer and softer and softer. He said "no I'm not going to overpower this drumset. I'm going to do it just exact opposite way. I'm going to give you things you don't expect. You don't expect the drums to be soft." So he started

out pretty good, and then every eight measures he got softer. He went down to brushes. Finally he put the brushes down and said "Just beat on the chest."

MR: Well he was some showman. You need some of that too. But soloing is a different art form. Because drummers, when I come up, we were mostly accompanists. You know we might not get a solo all night. Because most of the bands played dance music. And you know you can tell if a drummer has good time, if he gets a solo and he's playing dance music if the people still dance, then he's playing with feeling and he's playing with pulse. You've got to have pulse, you've got to have feeling, you've got to have dynamics, there's so much you've got to think of just to get from one note to the other one. It's not all technique and you know energy. I mean some drummers play a solo and they're just playing a lot of energy you know? And there's no music, they forget about the music. So I think that a drummer should also be musical. Because then it's easier to listen to. And then everybody that you're playing with, they know where you're at. You know they know where you're at in the song in terms of the song. Because you've got to play the song too.

MW: You know they say that a drummer can't play with the band. He has to be ahead of the band because he's got to set up everything.

MR: Well I don't know about that. You know I think that the drummer—

MW: I mean you have to think ahead.

MR: Oh I think everybody should think ahead. If you read, you have to read ahead. You can't be playing here and reading here, you've got to see that and then you're looking over here you know what I'm saying? But as far as playing, the drummer and the bass player should be just like this, just like one person. And it gives the soloists, they can play behind the beat. You know how Little Jimmy Scott sings? You know how Little Jimmy Scott sings behind the beat? And you see horn players can do that and piano players. But a drummer and a bass player, you've got to [claps] just like marching. Just like, you've got to be right on the beat.

MW: The designated driver.

MR: Yeah. You've got to be right on the beat man. And it gives them a foundation from which to throw their curve balls from you know?

MW: Tell us some of the other people that you've backed up. I noticed you worked with Nancy Wilson.

MR: Yes. Well see when I first went to New York I didn't know how to read music. You know I studied very briefly and then I got drafted in the Army. So when I came out of the Army I went to New York to play with Gigi, then I played with Ray Bryant, then Joe Williams. And when I left Joe Williams I took a gig with Mary Lou Williams in the Hickory House. And I worked with her for about a year off and on, then she got sick. So

during that time I decided I was going to stay in New York for a while. So I got hooked up with Duke Pearson and Duke Pearson more or less taught me how to read you know. Because he had a big band. And then he asked me to join his big band. And then he would write out stuff for me and then I started to learn, when I first started to learn how to read. So then I got the gig with Nancy Wilson. Because she had music for everything. And that was beautiful man, you know, that was one of the best jobs I ever had in my life was with Nancy Wilson. She used to pay us when we was off, you know? I had never had that. A retainer. She gave us a retainer. Me and Buster Williams was the rhythm section and a piano and a conductor named Don Trenner. So I did that for a while and then I left there and that's when I joined Lee Morgan's band. But during that time when I stayed in New York I made recordings with a lot of people like Stanley Turrentine and Horace Silver and Frank Foster, Donald Byrd.

MW: Let me ask you about that, 'cause you talked about Horace Silver. First of all the hard bop period is like some of my favorite music. Tell me about how that music feels from the inside out.

MR: Man it's just heaven man. It's strong and I was young man. You know we were all young guys you know, and it was beautiful man because it was so exciting for me, you know, because I never in my wildest imagination believed that I would be in New York playing with these guys I'd been looking at all my life you know. I always loved music you know, and I could always play the drums you know, but I never, you know I was married and I had two kids and I had to work a day job in the beginning. Until I went to New York. So I never dreamed that I would be playing with people like that I played with. So I was always excited man. To me it was like I died and went to heaven.

MW: I wanted to ask you, do you have any little, funny little things that happened to you like on the bandstand or while you were traveling with a group? Little crazy things that the average person may not think has anything to do with the music, but eventually finds its way into the music.

MR: Well that story I told about me playing in four-four and the music was in three-four, that's about the funniest story I got you know. Because you know there are a lot of stories but I can't think of one to tell you right now. Little funny stories.

MW: Tell us about working with Lee Morgan.

MR: Oh that was beautiful man. Now there is, I got a funny story to tell you about Lee Morgan. When I was working with Lee Morgan, I was invited to his house for dinner one night, when him and Helen was together you know? And they lived in the Bronx, not far from Yankee Stadium. So we're sitting there having dinner and all this, before, Lee Morgan, I mean Dizzy Gillespie and Art they would come and we'd play in Slug's quite a bit this club in the lower part of New York. So we're sitting having dinner and the

phone rings you know? So I don't know who it was on the other end, because Lee was talking on the phone. So I heard him say, "man I know why you're coming 'round all the time man, because you're trying to steal my drummer." And Dizzy was working at the Vanguard you know with his band. So Lee said, "just for that man, I ought to come down there and burn on you. I'll bring my horn down there and burn on you old man." And there was a pause, and then all of a sudden, Lee Morgan just broke out laughing. I mean he was hysterical laughing. So we're trying to find out what Dizzy said. So I said, "what did Dizzy say, man?" So he say what Dizzy say, "don't come down here to get bruised." But I'll tell you Dizzy, all the trumpet players called Dizzy Gillespie the king. I mean he is the king on that trumpet. There's nobody can play that trumpet like Dizzy Gillespie. And you know, and so Lee was teasing, you know so he say "well don't come down here to get bruised."

MW: Now that's something else I want to talk with you about because see this is all a part of the education of jazz is the cutting contest.

MR: Well that was more or less before my time. That cutting stuff. When I came along, cats were friendly and they were willing to help you.

MW: Oh it wasn't always to the death—

MR: I know verbally cutting — cats cut each other up musically. Is that what you're talking about?

MW: Yeah.

MR: Well that only happened to people who couldn't swing. They would get cut up. Because they would ruin the groove. That's what I mean about the blues. If you get a guy and he get on the bandstand and he play [scats] if he plays too staccato, guys would cut him up. Because it should be more liquid, fluid you know? Not so staccato, you know what I'm saying? Jazz is more legato.

MW: It's a legato art.

MR: I mean and then you instill a few staccato, just for the differences, you know to show your classical training or awareness you know? But it's more legato instead of staccato.

MW: And tell us for instance how you go about trying to accomplish that legato nature on a drumset.

MR: You listen to the masters. You duplicate your masters until you find it yourself, until you get it. And then you can be yourself. But everybody comes from somewhere. The history, you know you listen to the guys that originated the stuff. Listen to Kenny Clarke, you listen to Art Blakey. You know what I'm saying? You listen to Papa Jo Jones. You listen to Philly Joe Jones. These are the guys that I like, that I listen to, to see just how they emphasize a phrase, you see what I'm saying? And to see how they just take two bars and make a phrase. And then you try to do the same thing. Because you don't want to play the

same phrase — you might love him to death man, but you don't want to play the same thing he played in the same places. It gets stale. Because jazz is not like that. I mean this, in the beginning when you were a kid and all the young guys wanted to play "Sing Sing Sing" like Gene Krupa. You know that was a show that you really listened to Gene and you'd say, "man I can play 'Sing Sing Sing.'" But man you've got to get away from that. You've got to be yourself. You've got to learn how to express how you feel see and that's what's beautiful about jazz in comparison with other music. Other music you've got to be just like Bach or Beethoven or whatever you know? Okay we can be like Charlie Parker but we can also be like ourselves. And that's accepted as long as you're strong.

MW: You mentioned earlier on in our talk about the Gospel influence. Tell us how that finds its way into the music. And I want to mention a term here, and then you take off on it. There's a term that deals with several West African languages, called significant tone. And that means that the way that you pronounce a word, whether you give a higher inflection or a lower inflection to that tone, actually changes the meaning of the tone. And then of course I teach in my courses that when people came here from West Africa, and you play on a saxophone or a trumpet but your language was one that used significant tone, you're still trying to get those inflections out of that inanimate piece of metal. Make that thing speak and give you the sound that you want back.

MR: Well see you have to, like let's say you want to play Latin music. You cannot play Latin music until you live and, I mean you can play it but you won't be authentic. Just like we might learn French. We might go to school and learn how to speak French. But you won't speak French until you go to France and live in France. See music is an expression of life. You see? So you have to live, you've got to live and be with people to be able to express how they feel musically. Because the music comes from the people, the soul people or poor people or the soul of the music, like the Gospel. It comes from the poor people. The poor people of America, the people who have been abused, the people who have a lot to cry about and rejoice about. You see? So that's you know, expression comes from people. And the music comes from the people. You understand what I'm saying?

MW: There's a thing I want to ask you about, and this is a term that I use and let's see how you feel about it, a thing that I call emotional truth. Now I explained it like this. I said there is truth, which we call just fact, and then there's emotional truth. Now we all know that there was a Vietnam War. That's a fact. That is true. But if you're talking to a mother who lost her son in that war, and she breaks down and cry while you're talking to her, now that's the emotional truth.

MR: Well it's like looking at a picture. Some people look at a picture and they see something completely different. You know what I mean? You know if a mother lost her son, she'd look at a picture of the Vietnam War man, she's going to be affected quite differently

than some guy that was a soldier and got a medal for it. You know what I'm saying? So that's what that is you know.

MW: You know let me ask you another thing about jazz. Do you feel that let's say when a quintet is playing, piano, bass, drums, trumpet, sax, that there are different levels that an audience can listen at?

MR: I think it's up to the players. Because you could get a quintet and they might not be together. And if the audience listens, they're not going to enjoy it as much as if they listen to a quintet and the guys are together. It's up to the players to make the people listen. You demand, the player has to demand attention. Because the audience, they're hungry man, they want to hear whatever you got to say. So if you say something that's intelligent and logical and the truth, you got 'em captivated. But if you go out there caring more about the way you look or what you're wearing or you know are you playing just to try to get some chick or something, I mean how are you going to—it's serious. It's serious business.

MW: In other words how are you going to create something of great beauty if your motive is too weak?

MR: Right. You've got to soothe the savage beast in people. So you've got to be a dedicated player. People, you can't fool 'em. You know you can't fool people, they're hungry. And they know the truth now. They've listened to jazz for a long time. So you can't fool 'em. You know when you're playing and you play with the blues or you're playing and you're just technical playing, you know they know. You can't fool 'em now. People will get up and walk out on you. Or they'll stay there and listen.

MW: Let me ask you about that. What is one of the easiest audiences that you've ever played for, and what is one of the hardest audiences you've ever played for?

MR: I don't think there is such a thing. Because if you are a dedicated player, you're going to play your heart out. I don't care if you're playing in the parking lot. You know what I'm saying? Sometimes you play a Jazzmobile where you're riding in the street and you're playing for people in different neighborhoods. That don't mean that you should give up less there then you would give up in Carnegie Hall. Your dedication is sad if you do that. So that's, you know, there's no easy audience and there's no hard audience. You know what I'm saying? What makes the audience is the player.

MW: He's a catalyst.

MR: Huh?

MW: You're a catalyst.

MR: Right. You're the bottom line. They want to hear you man. There's a big audience for people that can really speak intelligently. And you don't have to say every word in the

dictionary but make people understand and love your sound and your approach. You know it takes a lot of dedication man to get from one note to the other one man.

MW: Let me ask you an elusive word, and you just give me your definition of it however you can. Try to define for me the word groove.

MR: Groove. Groove to me is a blues, a term that depicts the blues. And when you're playing and you look at an audience and everybody is groovin'. And you look in the audience man and you see everybody doing this, that's groove, that's a groove. But if you're playing something and everybody's talking, that's no groove. A groove man, when a player plays, when a band plays or a player, it can be a solo guy by himself, two guys, ten guys, but it's the feeling. See that's the feeling of the blues. It's the groove. And you're playing man, and it doesn't matter what tempo it is, but usually a groove tempo is, when they say a groove, the tempo is usually a moderate tempo. But that's not, you can groove in any tempo. But basically people think of a groove when you say a groove tempo, and you look at an audience man, and people are — that's what groove means.

MW: In other words there's a communication going on there.

MR: Oh yeah. You can communicate without being a groove. Now because sometimes you can play, you can play rubato -- without tempo, you know what I mean? And you can communicate. But when you groove, there's a pulse, there's a pulse happening man. And people feel it man. And you know they feel it man because you can see 'em.

MW: You know I want to ask you something else you know, back to some aspects of church, particularly the African-American church. You know when I listen to preachers, they're not necessarily singers, but I hear in their voice a certain cadence, you know, and it's almost like it's musical construction.

MR: Yeah, they're blues singers. That's where blues singers come from man, listening to them deacons getting ready for the preacher.

MW: Give us an example. Give us an example.

MR: I'm not too good at it, [humms]—I can't really do it. But I know it when I hear it. But everything comes out of the church. Well you know the spiritual value of music is something that you must have. Spirit. That's what the blues comes from, see, the Gospel. And the Negro spirituals in the corn field. Because see they took the drums away from us when we were slaves because we could communicate with each other. And they wanted to separate us, the slave masters. And when we was working on the plantation. So we learned Gospel music. They would make up spiritual songs like [sings] lead me to the water. You know and they would send messages that way, see? And out of that come the blues singers like Dinah Washington and Sarah Vaughan. They come out of the churches, and Mahalia Jackson, you know, she was a spiritual singer, but if you listen to Aretha Franklin, you know what I'm saying? Ray Charles. See but and then it kept evolving.

Then you've got Charlie Parker, you've got Coleman Hawkins, they started swinging a little more and Ben Webster and Benny Carter, and it got more advanced with Dizzy Gillespie and Charlie Parker. See but it all come out of the fields. See it come out of them cotton fields, you know, with the Negro spiritual. It's real sophisticated now. You go in the church and they've got drums and everything, bass you know? I mean dreadlocks. The Baptist churches, you go and look on the pulpit there's a set of drums up there with two tom toms all around and bass and it sounds to me just like James Brown and them.

MW: You know now you were talking about the communication with the spirituals. Basically they would say if a man was working in a field next to a pretty woman and he was singing "Steal Away," he wasn't talking about God, he was talking about, hey if you were half as tired of working as I am after you get off tonight let's hook up.

MR: The beat goes on you know. Even God said, "go forth and multiply." You know that's very important. You know there's always a way.

MW: You also talked about the drums in West African society being a form of communication and that was a form of using significant tones.

MR: That's how they speak to each other. Whatever tone. You know they had kinds of sounds for different messages that they wanted to send. And not only the sound but the way the sound was projected, you know, tells a story. But you have to live, like again like I say, you have to live in order to understand these sounds. There's no way that somebody that don't live there can tell you what these guys are saying. You know what they're doing, they're sending messages, which you don't know what the messages, see that's what made 'em take the drums away. Because they didn't know. They couldn't understand what these slaves were saying. So they just took the drums, you know, I mean after they come to America, and so that's how—

MW: I wanted to just share with you something that I think is important and then you give me your feedback on it. You know when I listen to music, particularly jazz music and a lot of the great, particular African-American performers, there's an authenticity in that music that I get that refreshes me, that revitalizes me, it's something that for instance if I pick up an album of a player that I like and I put that album on, even if I've never met that player, I feel like I've had a conversation with him you know?

MR: Yeah, because he's having one with you you know? But the best way to hear music is live if possible. I know it's impossible for a lot of young people because they can't afford to go hear music. It's very expensive to go hear music nowadays. When I come up it was inexpensive to go out and hear music, but we still had to wait until a certain age. So recordings was a way that we had to listen to these guys, you know. And the only thing about recordings is when you make a record, I made a lot of records, you stop, if there's a mistake made you stop, and you start, if somebody makes a mistake — not the sideman,

only the band leader — if the band leader makes a mistake you stop but if the sideman makes a mistake you better catch up on the next beat.

MW: You have to live with it. You know what one guy told me? He told me they would do two or three takes and he was a sideman but he would get a solo now and then. So when he got a solo and did the burning solo, he would go to the lead man and say, "don't you want to keep take number two?"

MR: They edit, you know they edit. They keep the take that the band leader sounds the best on. They don't care about what you sound like. They care, you know what I mean, but they care more about what they sound like. See so I've learned that recording for me is hard. Because you try to play without making mistakes. See so right then if the music is classical, you're thinking classically. Because there's no room for mistakes in classical music. But in jazz, live jazz, if you make a mistake man, you can — because you've got to reach. It's not a music where you're just satisfied and you play something that you know right now, you're always trying to stretch, to go a little further. That's how you better yourself. But in classical music, you learn just the way that the composer intended, you play it that way every time. You see you just develop your sound. Those cats have great sound. I'm not putting the music down I'm just saying the differences in the two musics. All music is beautiful to me. But I'm just saying even in rock music, it's the same. You've got to sound just like the record. If it's a hit, you know you can't change anything. In jazz, you can change. You know you don't have to do the same thing all the time. And that's refreshing. It keeps the music refreshed and new all the time. Because you can play a song ten times and every time it will be a different solo, it'll be different. Because it's not worked out. And if it's worked out, then again we go into the classics again.

MW: Like it becomes chamber music almost.

MR: Right, you know. And that's boring after a while. It's like eating breakfast, bacon and eggs every morning. You wake up every morning of your life and you eat bacon and eggs. Man you get sick of bacon and eggs after a while.

MW: Well I want to ask you as we kind of close here, if you had an encouragement that you could give to young drummers on the way up. I know you talked about hearing the music live.

MR: Well I think that the first thing they should do is cherish their friends. Because without their friends, you have nothing. I think you should stay clean, don't use no drugs, don't use no drugs, don't smoke no cigarettes, you know, and then your mind is free to learn music. See 'cause you have to have a free mind. You can't be bogged down with sidetracks. You know what I'm saying? But the main thing is to cherish your friends man, because they're the only people that's going to call you for work is your friends.

MW: That's beautiful. We have been filming here on location on the Royal Caribbean Cruise Line and we've been talking with Mickey Roker, a fabulous jazz drummer that's played with many of the greats, and we are filming this jazz archive for Hamilton College. Thank you.

MR: Thank you.